which is 'change the business'. The challenge, according to Ramamoorthy, is that while earlier shifts were in individual, monolithic technologies such as mainframe, client server, internet, mobile, etc., characterised by disruption followed by long periods of stability, current technologies are multiple—cloud, analytics, cybersecurity, AI, IoT, blockchain, 3D printing and quantum. "With such a high velocity of change, the challenges have been compounded," says Ramamoorthy.

Rising to the Challenge

How can companies as well job-seekers navigate this changing landscape? Indian IT firms have been quick to adapt to the changing environment. Wipro, for instance, said nearly all its employees have completed 'foundational GenAI training', while over 87,000 received role-specific programmes tailored to their domains. "We are actively building an AI-ready workforce covering over 230,000 employees by fostering an AI-first mindset and equipping them with essential AI skill sets and toolsets," it said in its FY25 annual report. "We have enabled over 50 AI learning pathways tailored to varied proficiency levels for our business and technical associates... Across our delivery teams, we have over 20,000 associates leveraging AI developer tools to boost our overall productivity."

Meanwhile, Infosys, whose digital reskilling programme includes the latest GenAI courses, says over 270,000 of its employees today (83 per cent) "are AI-aware". According to the company's FY25 annual report, it delivered over 400 GenAI projects via its generative and agentic AI-powered services and solutions platform called Infosys Topaz, including building four small language models for banking, IT operations, cyber and enterprises.

The Indian IT services industry has always been evolving and adapting to tech changes from the early '80s," says Gopalakrishnan. "From mainframes to UNIX and midrange systems, to personal computers with DOS, Windows, mac OS, to Internet, to mobile technologies and social networks, the industry has adapted. It has grown from nothing to $300 billion. It has strong balance sheets, is highly profitable, with mature and experienced management, loyal customers, and has experienced many downturns over the years. I believe it will survive this one too." Experts advocate replacing the existing legacy framework with lean, outcome-driven teams, AI automation and cloud-native delivery. They must pivot to product-led platform-first strategies or risk obsolescence.



> "IT firms are getting a significant portion of their revenues from **'run the business' work as opposed to transformational, 'change the business' work**. While earlier shifts were in single, monolithic technology, current technologies are multiple, compounding the challenge"
>
> **— RAMKUMAR RAMAMOORTHY**
> *Partner, Catalincs*

Ramamoorthy believes companies need to do two things to participate in growth opportunities: be agile, and reinvest profits back into the business. "It calls for much more investment than before, given that we have to run multiple races at the same time." Companies must take bold, unconventional decisions to 'force-cannibalise' revenues wherever appropriate, and invest their way out. Firms like TCS are boosting their conventional AI offerings via strategic partnerships, such as the one with AI firm Vianai Systems. "You can't get stuck with old operating models when there are structural shifts in the marketplace," says Ramamoorthy. "Now, every industry and their business, operating and financial models have to be reimagined. That's why AI is more a structural force than a tool. And companies have to make investments beyond reskilling and upskilling their employees."

Gopalakrishnan believes entry-level employees must be trained on AI tools. Universities have just begun introducing these tools; including them in the curriculum and training faculty will take time. They need to design new pedagogy to teach using AI tools, giving assignments that allow students to use AI tools, and evaluating student skills. The skills-gap will persist given the rapid pace at which these technologies evolve. Learning, says the headhunter quoted above, is "a dual responsibility. I, as a professional, must learn to upgrade and upskill myself, apart from whatever training my organisation is giving." Also, there is nothing called the 'backend' today; everyone will need competencies that make them holistic". While the change is relentless, so are the learning avenues and flow of information, says Gurnani. "I strongly believe that learning to learn is what will differentiate you. Adapt to the new ways of thinking, learning and unlearning, and applying knowledge effectively. While tools will tell you what to do, don't forget that it is an (entrepreneurial) instinct that creates big businesses."

The Indian IT story continues to be robust; it needs to keep up with the pace of change and prepare for it. While companies need to shape up to sustain amidst the flux technology has unleashed, IT job-seekers as well as workers need to realise that their once-prized job may have either moved entirely or taken a new shape, for which they need to shape up. Or ship out. ■